

50 Powerful Windows Commands to Save Time

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Every command in this guide is built into Windows. No downloads, no installations, no admin rights for most of them. Whether you're managing files, diagnosing problems, or just trying to look like a hacker in front of your friends -- these are the 50 commands worth knowing.

Categories

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How to use this guide: Open CMD or Terminal as Administrator (right-click Start > Terminal (Admin)). Commands marked with * require admin privileges. Everything else works in a regular terminal.

#1

tree

Visual map of your entire folder structure. Instantly see how your drive is organized without clicking through anything.

```
tree C:\Users\YourName\Documents
```

#2

tree /f

Same as tree but includes every individual file, not just folders. Full X-ray of your drive.

```
tree /f C:\Projects > project_map.txt
```

#3

dir /s /b

List every file in a directory and all sub-directories. The `/b` flag gives clean output with just file paths -- perfect for piping to other commands.

```
dir /s /b *.pdf
```

#4

robocopy

Robust file copy. Way faster and more reliable than drag-and-drop for large transfers. Supports resume on failure, mirror mode, and multi-threaded copying.

```
robocopy C:\Source D:\Backup /MIR /MT:8
```

#5

xcopy

Extended copy -- copies files, directories, and sub-directories. Lighter than robocopy, great for quick backups.

```
xcopy C:\Work D:\Backup\Work /E /H /I
```

#6

ren

Rename files. Supports wildcards so you can batch-rename hundreds of files in one command.

```
ren *.jpeg *.jpg
```

#7

mklink

Create symbolic links -- make a folder appear in two places without copying it. Essential for moving game installs to another drive without breaking things.

```
mklink /D "C:\Games\MyGame" "D:\Games\MyGame"
```

#8

attrib

Change file attributes. Make files hidden, read-only, or reveal hidden system files that Explorer won't show you.

```
attrib -h -s -r C:\hidden_folder /S /D
```

#9

where

Find the exact location of any executable on your system. Like "which" on Linux.

```
where python
```

#10

forfiles

Batch process files by criteria -- date, size, extension. Delete all files older than 30 days? One command.

```
forfiles /p C:\Temp /s /d -30 /c "cmd /c del @file"
```

#11

systeminfo

Complete system specs in one command -- OS version, RAM, processor, network adapters, boot time, hotfixes installed. Everything a tech support person asks for.

```
systeminfo
```

#12

driverquery

Full audit of every driver on your machine. Shows name, type, install date, and status. Export to CSV to find the outdated one causing crashes.

```
driverquery /v /fo csv > drivers.csv
```

#13 *

sfc /scannow

System File Checker. Scans all protected system files and replaces corrupted ones. Run this after any crash or unexpected behavior.

```
sfc /scannow
```

#14 *

DISM /Online /Cleanup-Image /RestoreHealth

Repairs the Windows component store -- the source SFC uses to fix files. Always run this BEFORE sfc /scannow for best results.

```
DISM /Online /Cleanup-Image /RestoreHealth
```

#15

msinfo32

Opens the System Information GUI. More detailed than systeminfo -- shows hardware resources, components, software environment, and conflict reports.

```
msinfo32
```

#16

winver

Instantly shows your exact Windows version and build number. Useful when checking if you have the latest feature update.

```
winver
```

#17

hostname

Shows your computer's network name. Quick way to identify which machine you're on when managing multiple PCs.

```
hostname
```

#18

wmic bios get serialnumber

Pull your PC's serial number without flipping the laptop over. Works for manufacturer, model, and BIOS version too.

```
wmic bios get serialnumber
```

Network & Connectivity (19-26)

#19

ipconfig /all

Full network configuration -- IP address, subnet mask, gateway, DNS servers, MAC address, DHCP status. The first command to run for any network issue.

```
ipconfig /all
```

#20

ping

Test if a server is reachable and measure response time. `ping 8.8.8.8` tests raw internet. `ping google.com` tests DNS + internet.

```
ping google.com -t
```

#21

tracert

Trace the route packets take to reach a destination. Shows every hop between you and the server -- find where the bottleneck is.

```
tracert google.com
```

#22

netstat -an

Shows all active network connections and listening ports. See exactly what's connected to your PC and on which ports. Great for spotting suspicious connections.

```
netstat -an | findstr "ESTABLISHED"
```

#23

nslookup

Query DNS servers directly. Find out what IP address a domain resolves to, or troubleshoot DNS issues.

```
nslookup google.com 1.1.1.1
```

#24 *

netsh winsock reset

Nuclear reset for your network stack. Fixes "connected but no internet," DNS failures, and most post-update network issues.

```
netsh winsock reset
```

#25

arp -a

Shows the ARP cache -- maps IP addresses to MAC addresses on your network. See every device that's communicated with your PC recently.

```
arp -a
```

#26

pathping

Combines ping + tracert. Tests each hop for packet loss over time. Best tool for diagnosing intermittent connection drops.

```
pathping google.com
```

Performance & Process Management (27-33)

#27

tasklist

List every running process with PID, memory usage, and session info. Like Task Manager but filterable and scriptable.

```
tasklist /fi "memusage gt 100000"
```

#28 *

taskkill

Force-kill any process by name or PID. When an app freezes and Task Manager can't close it -- this can.

```
taskkill /f /im chrome.exe
```

#29 *

powercfg /batteryreport

Generates a detailed HTML report of your laptop's battery health -- design capacity vs. current capacity, charge/discharge cycles, usage history.

```
powercfg /batteryreport /output "%USERPROFILE%\Desktop\battery.html"
```

#30 *

powercfg /energy

60-second energy efficiency scan. Finds processes wasting power, misconfigured settings, and hardware issues draining your battery.

```
powercfg /energy /output "%USERPROFILE%\Desktop\energy.html"
```

#31

wmic process get name,processid,workingsetsize

Detailed process info -- see exact memory usage per process. Filter to find the memory hog.

```
wmic process where "workingsetsize>1000000000" get  
name,processid,workingsetsize
```

#32 *

perfmon /report

Generates a comprehensive 60-second system performance report. CPU, disk, network, memory -- with specific warnings and recommendations.

```
perfmon /report
```

#33

resmon

Opens Resource Monitor -- real-time view of CPU, memory, disk, and network usage per process. More detailed than Task Manager's Performance tab.

```
resmon
```

Disk & Storage (34-38)

#34 *

chkdsk /f /r

Check Disk -- scans for file system errors and bad sectors. Your early warning system for a dying drive.

```
chkdsk C: /f /r
```


#35 *

diskpart

Interactive disk partition tool. Create, delete, resize, and format partitions. Also cleans USB drives that Windows can't format normally.

```
diskpart > list disk > select disk 1 > clean > create partition  
primary > format fs=ntfs quick
```

#36

cleanmgr

Disk Cleanup utility. Removes temp files, system cache, old Windows Update files. The `/d` flag specifies the drive.

```
cleanmgr /d C: /sageset:1
```

#37

fsutil volume diskfree C:

Instant, exact disk space report. Total bytes, free bytes, available bytes. No GUI needed.

```
fsutil volume diskfree C:
```

#38 *

cipher /w:C:

Securely wipes free space on a drive. After deleting sensitive files, this overwrites the free space so data can't be recovered.

```
cipher /w:C:\Users\YourName\Documents
```

Security & Permissions (39-43)

#39

whoami /all

Shows your current username, group memberships, and security privileges. Quick way to check if you have admin rights.

```
whoami /priv
```

#40 *

net user

List all user accounts on the system. Add, remove, or modify users. Reset forgotten passwords without reinstalling Windows.

```
net user
```

#41 *

net localgroup administrators

See exactly who has admin access on your PC. Add or remove users from the administrators group.

```
net localgroup administrators
```

#42 *

icaccls

View and modify file/folder permissions. Fix "Access Denied" errors by taking ownership and resetting permissions.

```
icaccls C:\LockedFolder /grant YourName:F /t
```

#43

cipher /c

Check the encryption status of files and folders. See what's encrypted on your system and with which certificate.

```
cipher /c C:\Users\YourName\Documents
```

Power & Startup (44-47)

#44

shutdown /r /t 0

Instant restart. The `/t 0` means zero-second delay. Also: `shutdown /s /t 0` for instant shutdown. Remote shutdown with `/m \\computername`.

```
shutdown /r /t 0
```

#45

shutdown /r /o /t 0

Restart directly into Advanced Startup Options (BIOS/UEFI, Safe Mode, Recovery).
Saves you from mashing F2 or DEL during boot.

```
shutdown /r /o /t 0
```

#46 *

bcdedit

View and modify your boot configuration. Enable Safe Mode, set default OS in dual-boot, or fix boot sequence issues.

```
bcdedit /enum
```

#47

msconfig

System Configuration utility. Manage startup programs, boot options, and services.
Enable diagnostic or selective startup for troubleshooting.

```
msconfig
```

Hidden Gems (48-50)

#48

clip

Pipe any command's output directly to your clipboard. Instead of scrolling and copying, just add `| clip` to any command.

```
ipconfig /all | clip
```

#49

fc

File Compare -- shows the exact differences between two files, line by line. Perfect for comparing config files or checking what changed.

```
fc /n file1.txt file2.txt
```

#50

assoc / ftype

Control which programs open which file types. `assoc` maps extensions to file types. `ftype` maps file types to programs. Fix "Open With" issues permanently.

```
assoc .txt ftype txtfile
```

Quick Cheat Sheet

Situation	Command
PC crashing randomly	<code>sfc /scannow</code>
Internet not working	<code>netsh winsock reset</code>
Need system specs	<code>systeminfo</code>
Find outdated drivers	<code>driverquery /v /fo list</code>
App won't close	<code>taskkill /f /im app.exe</code>
Check battery health	<code>powercfg /batteryreport</code>
Map all folders	<code>tree /f</code>
Copy large files fast	<code>robocopy /MIR /MT:8</code>
Delete old files	<code>forfiles /d -30 /c "cmd /c del @file"</code>
Check disk health	<code>chkdsk C: /f /r</code>

Need Personalized Help?

Got questions specific to your setup? Book a 1:1 call:

Rescue Call (30 min) - Rs. 2499

Quick fix, audit existing setup, solve specific issue

Book Rescue Call

Strategy Session (45 min) - Rs. 2999

Full planning, complete system optimization

Book Strategy Session

Questions? DM me on Instagram [@rahulmhinduja](#)